ConnectBox Translations Guide

Version 3 – Oct 27, 2026. Replaces Version 2 (Oct 7, 2026): translation files now ship for 46 languages, so units need no internet for them, and the captive portal page is translated from the same files.

What is translated

The menu's own wording (section titles, media type names, the Language button, the Configuration link, the chat labels, the "Loading new content" page and the "Speaker notes" label on presentations) and the captive portal page (the "Connected to … Wifi" page a phone shows when it joins the ConnectBox Wi-Fi) are shown in the visitor's language. The ConnectBox software only has this wording in English, so the translations are kept in one file per language on the unit.

How it works

- Each time a USB drive is loaded, the content loader (mmiLoader.py) writes the menu wording for every language folder on the drive from `/usr/local/connectbox/translations/<code>.json` (for example `es.json`). This also happens on a quick load from saved.zip, so a correction shows up without re-indexing.
- Translation files are installed with the software for 46 languages, covering the list of the 50 most spoken languages, so a unit that is never online still has them: Amharic, Arabic, Egyptian Arabic, Bengali, Bhojpuri, Burmese, Chinese (Simplified, Hong Kong Traditional and Taiwan Traditional), Farsi, French, German, Gujarati, Hausa, Hindi, Igbo, Indonesian, Italian, Japanese, Javanese, Kannada, Korean, Maithili, Malayalam, Marathi, Nigerian Pidgin, Odia, Oromo, Portuguese, Romanian, Russian, Sindhi, Spanish, Sundanese, Swahili, Tagalog, Tamil, Telugu, Thai, Turkish, Ukrainian, Urdu, Uzbek, Vietnamese, Western Punjabi (Shahmukhi) and Yoruba. English is built in. Their source is `ansible/roles/bootstrap/files/translations/` in the connectbox-pi repository.
- For any language not in that list, if the unit has internet, the English wording is translated online once (MyMemory, no account needed) and saved in a new file there, so it keeps working offline. With no internet the menu stays in English and the lookup is tried again on the next USB insert.
- Right-to-left languages (Arabic, Egyptian Arabic, Farsi, Hebrew, Urdu, Pashto, Sindhi, Western Punjabi, Kurdish Sorani, Uyghur, Yiddish, Dhivehi) are marked automatically, so the page flips direction.
- Language folder names are matched to these files through the language code list on the unit, so folders named with 3-letter codes (spa, ara, per) also find the right file. Chinese varieties use the written form chosen for them: Mandarin (cmn), Wu (wuu), Jin (cjy) and Hakka (hak) use Simplified Chinese, Cantonese (yue) uses Hong Kong Traditional and Min Nan (nan) uses Taiwan Traditional. Standard Arabic (arb) uses the Arabic file and Iranian Persian (pes) the Farsi file; Egyptian Arabic (arz) has its own file in Egyptian wording.
- Which language a visitor sees: the menu, the "Loading new content" page and the captive portal page start in the first of the phone's languages (its browser language setting) that the unit has content in, matching the exact code first (pt-BR) and then the base language (pt); otherwise the unit's default language. A language picked with the Language button is remembered and always wins in the menu.

Where the translation files are

There is one file per language, named with its language code (`es.json`, `zh-CN.json`, `arz.json` …). The same files are kept in three places:

- **Master copies (for every new unit):** in the connectbox-pi repository, `ansible/roles/bootstrap/files/translations/` (on Kirk's PC: `C:\Users\kirkw\Documents\Github\connectbox-pi\ansible\roles\bootstrap\files\translations\`). Ansible copies this folder to each unit it builds. Corrections made here reach every unit built or re-provisioned afterwards.
- **On each unit:** `/usr/local/connectbox/translations/<code>.json`. The content loader (mmiLoader.py) and the captive portal read the wording from here, and a language looked up online is saved here too. This is the copy to edit for a quick fix on one unit.
- **Written for the menu (do not edit):** `/var/www/enhanced/content/www/assets/content/<code>/data/interface.json`, one per language folder on the USB drive. The content loader rewrites these from the files above on every USB load, so changes made here are lost.

The language names on the Language button come from a separate list, `/var/www/enhanced/content/www/assets/templates/languageCodes.json`, not from these files.

The translation files

Each file lists every label with three values:

- `en` – the English the translation was made from. If the English changes in a later software version, that label is translated again; otherwise a corrected `text` is never replaced.
- `text` – the wording shown on screen. This is the value to correct.
- `source` – where the wording came from, for example "reviewed on test unit 2026-10-05" or "native check advised".

Label key	English	Where it appears
CATEGORIES_TITLE	Categories	Section title
CHAT_MESSAGE	Type a message	Chat message box
CHAT_NAME	Name	Chat name box
CHAT_TITLE	Chat	Chat page title
EPISODES_TEXT	Episodes	Collection pages
FOOTER_CONFIGURATION	Configuration	Bottom-left link
INDEXING_TEXT	This ConnectBox is loading new media. The menu will appear here by itself when it is ready.	Loading page
INDEXING_TITLE	Loading new content	Loading page
LANGUAGE_BUTTON	Language	Header button
MEDIA_TYPE.APPLICATION	App	Card and detail labels
MEDIA_TYPE.AUDIO	Audio	Card and detail labels
MEDIA_TYPE.DOCUMENT	Document	Card and detail labels
MEDIA_TYPE.HTML	Web Document	Card and detail labels
MEDIA_TYPE.IMAGE	Image	Card and detail labels
MEDIA_TYPE.TEXT	Text File	Card and detail labels
MEDIA_TYPE.VIDEO	Video	Card and detail labels

MEDIA_TYPE.ZIP	Archive	Card and detail labels
MISSING_MEDIA_TEXT	We're working on collecting the data or Something went wrong! The media is missing!	Error page
MISSING_MEDIA_TITLE	Media is missing!	Error page
OTHER_MEDIA_TITLE	Media	Section title
PORTAL_GO_TO	Go to {url}	Captive portal: link to the menu
PORTAL_NOT_CLOSING	If this page does not close after OK, tap ⋮ (top right) and choose {option}.	Captive portal: hint on newer Android phones
PORTAL_OK	OK	Captive portal: button
PORTAL_TITLE	Connected to {name} Wifi	Captive portal: page title
PORTAL_TYPE_ADDRESS	Type {url} in your browser	Captive portal: picture caption
PORTAL_USE_AS_IS	Use this network as is	Captive portal: Android's menu item, quoted in the hint
RECOMMENDED_TEXT	Recommended	Home page
RECOMMENDED_TITLE	For You	Home page
SLIDE_NOTES	Speaker notes	Presentation pages
UNSUPPORTED_TEXT	Sorry, your browser does not support videos.	Video player

In the captive portal labels, {name} (the unit's name), {url} (its address) and {option} (the Android menu item) are filled in by the unit; keep them in the translation. PORTAL_USE_AS_IS must be Android's own wording of "Use this network as is" in that language, so it matches what the phone shows; for languages Android is not translated into (Bhojpuri, Hausa, Igbo, Javanese, Maithili, Nigerian Pidgin, Oromo, Sindhi, Sundanese, Western Punjabi, Yoruba) it is left in English on purpose, and the hint says top right. In right-to-left languages Android shows ⋮ at the top left.

Correcting a translation

A fix made only on a unit is lost when the unit is re-provisioned with Ansible, so make lasting fixes in the repository as well.

On a unit:

1. Log in: `ssh root@<unit address>`.
2. Keep a copy: `cp /usr/local/connectbox/translations/es.json /root/es.json.bak` (use the language's code).
3. Edit only the `text` value of the label: `nano /usr/local/connectbox/translations/es.json`. Keep the quotes and commas as they are, and set `source` to say who checked it.
4. Check the file: `python3 -m json.tool /usr/local/connectbox/translations/es.json > /dev/null && echo OK`.
5. Unplug and re-insert the USB drive (or restart the unit). The menu is rewritten with the new wording; a normal browser refresh shows it. The captive portal page uses a corrected file straight away.

For all future units: make the same change in `ansible/roles/bootstrap/files/translations/<code>.json`, commit and push.

Adding a language

Put the content in a folder named with the language code (for example nl). If there is no file for that language and the unit is online during the first load, the labels are looked up and saved in `/usr/local/connectbox/translations/nl.json`. Online translations of short menu words are often poor, so have a native speaker check that file, then copy it into the repository folder above so every unit gets the reviewed version. You can also write the file yourself first (copy es.json, set language, and replace each text); the unit then does not look anything up.

Waiting for a native speaker check

Language	Labels marked "native check advised"
Arabic (ar), Spanish (es), Portuguese (pt), Chinese Simplified (zh-CN)	LANGUAGE_BUTTON, MEDIA_TYPE.APPLICATION, INDEXING_TITLE, INDEXING_TEXT, SLIDE_NOTES, PORTAL_TITLE, PORTAL_GO_TO, PORTAL_TYPE_ADDRESS, PORTAL_NOT_CLOSING
Farsi (fa) and the 30 languages added Oct 26, 2026 that Android is translated into	All labels except PORTAL_USE_AS_IS and PORTAL_OK, which are Android's own wording
Bhojpuri, Hausa, Igbo, Javanese, Maithili, Nigerian Pidgin, Oromo, Sindhi, Sundanese, Western Punjabi, Yoruba	All labels except PORTAL_USE_AS_IS (English on purpose, see above)

Very old phones may not have fonts for some scripts (Burmese, Amharic, Odia and other Indian scripts) and then show boxes instead of letters. Burmese is in Unicode; phones still using the older Zawgyi encoding show it garbled.

What is not translated

- Content titles (books, videos, PDFs) – they come from the file and folder names on the USB drive.
- The "ConnectBox" name in the header – it comes from the unit's brand setting.
- Language button names (Español, العربية, 中文 …) – they come from the language name list on the unit (`languageCodes.json`), not from these files.
- Chat messages – shown as typed; only their text direction follows the sender's language.